

Financially Sovereign Academy

Correctional and Reentry Program

Budgeting & Emergency Savings

Partner / Funder Packet

Version 0.1 (provisional) · 2026-07-04

Provisional pilot-ready draft. External counsel review pending. Not for final facility distribution until legal/privacy feedback is reconciled.

Described as pilot-ready, never proven or validated. No outcome or recidivism claims.
Not legally approved. Source & Claims Ledger held at v0.2.

Module Brief: Budgeting & Emergency Savings (v0.2)

Program: Correctional and Reentry (build order #2 system-wide) Version: v0.2 (brief) | Date: 2026-07-02 | Status: Needs Dalia review (v0.1 was Approved; v0.2 adds the Ontology Spine per D-12, all other sections carried forward unchanged) Supersedes: budgeting-emergency-savings-brief-v0.1.md (kept as history) Sources: none cited in this brief; facts are design assumptions or flagged in Source Items Needed. No learner-facing numbers yet. Shape: 4 sessions x 90 minutes plus optional 5th capstone/review; each session standalone. Paper-first, nine-piece deliverable set.

0. Ontology Spine (D-12)

1. **What is this module really about beneath the surface?** Not category tracking. In this reentry module, budgeting is triage under pressure, income timing, obligation management, shock absorption, family pressure, and the creation of future options.
2. **Core concepts:** scarcity, triage order, the floor (planning to the worst week), income timing vs due dates, obligations (negotiable vs fixed), shock absorption, pressure (family, urgency, fear), true cost of fast money, backup moves, future options.
3. **Learner pressures connected to those concepts:** release-cash reality, supervision obligations, gratitude debt and guilt toward family, irregular income, fixed transitional-housing fees, no cheap credit access, shame about small numbers.
4. **System forces shaping choices:** fee extraction aimed at thin margins, predatory credit that appears exactly at shock moments, benefits timing gaps, documentation loops (ID needs the birth certificate), pay cycles that do not match billing cycles.
5. **Traps and incentives that distort good decisions:** fast money risks the thing that earns the money; silence feels safer than the early ask; visible cash invites claims; installments stack against irregular income; other people manufacture urgency.
6. **Shallow version to avoid:** “make a budget and stick to it.” Budgeting as spreadsheet discipline or personal virtue. A broken budget as personal failure.
7. **What the learner should see differently after:** most money crises here are timing-and-order problems under pressure, not character problems; an early phone call is a financial tool; the plan that matters is the one that survives the bad week.
8. **Concepts that repeat across scenarios:** triage order, the floor, the early ask, the backup move, true cost, protect-the-earner.
9. **Concepts that belong elsewhere and must not be over-taught here:** fee mechanics and accounts (Banking & Credit), collections rights / restitution / child support strategy (Debt module), scam anatomy (Scams module), paystub mechanics (Workforce).
10. **One-sentence ontology spine:** When money is short, the skill is slowing the damage, protecting the next step, asking early, and keeping one option open.

The learner should not leave thinking “I need a perfect budget.” The learner should leave thinking: “When money is short, I can slow the damage, protect the next step,

ask early, and keep one option open.”

1. Learner profile

Mixed room: people preparing for release (weeks to months out, no income now, working with estimates) and people recently released (roughly the first six months, working with real numbers). Recent money reality is commissary and trust accounts, where money was small, tracked by someone else, and spent in one place. Now money arrives small and irregular (gate money, family help, day labor, first paychecks) while obligations arrive fixed and stacked. Mixed literacy and numeracy. Some have never run a household; others ran one and lost it. Family may be managing their money. Works even without ID, phone, bank account, or job.

2. Real-world problem

In the first 90 days out, money in is irregular and money out is not: supervision costs, child support, phone, transport, housing contribution, work clothes. A budget built like a spreadsheet dies on contact with one bad week. One small shock (a bus pass, a tool, a fee) breaks the whole month, and the pressure moment that follows is exactly when the expensive options appear: payday loans, advances, informal borrowing, family conflict. This module teaches budgeting as **triage under pressure**, not category tracking, and savings as **a small shock absorber**, not a wealth plan.

3. Learning goals

Learners understand: how to decide what gets paid when everything cannot be paid; how to plan around irregular income instead of pretending it is steady; what actually counts as an emergency; why a small cushion changes their negotiating position with every trap; how family money pressure works and how to answer it without burning the relationship; why the most available money in a bad week is usually the most expensive.

4. What learners should be able to do by the end

Fill out a one-week money map on paper. Sort a stack of bill cards into “pay now / negotiate / later” and defend the order (stay housed, stay fed, stay legal, stay working). Make one plan that survives both a good week and a bad week. Write their own one-line definition of an emergency and use it on a sorting drill. Name a realistic first cushion rung for their situation, including “zero this week, with a date.” Deliver one practiced sentence in response to a family money ask. Pick the least expensive option from a set of realistic “fast money” offers and say why.

5. Common misconceptions

Budgeting means restriction and punishment. “I have too little money to budget” (triage matters most when money is smallest). An emergency fund does not count until it hits \$1,000 (illustrative threshold; the first \$25 changes outcomes). A budget that got broken once has failed. Pay whoever pressures loudest first. Supervision

fees and child support can wait until I am back on my feet (dangerous: consequences can include supervision problems; module teaches “ask early, in writing” and routes to the officer or free legal aid, never gives case advice). A credit card or loan can be my emergency fund.

6. Emotional barriers

Shame about small numbers and about looking at the numbers at all. Debt of gratitude: “they held me down while I was inside, I cannot say no.” Scarcity fatigue and present-bias after years when money was abstract. Pride that blocks asking for help or negotiating a bill. Fear that a plan is just another thing to fail at. A partner or relative who controls the money. Grief about lost years expressed as spending.

7. Likely scams, fees, traps, and pressure points

Payday and title loans at the exact moment of a shock. Paycheck-advance and cash-advance apps that look free. Rent-to-own pricing. Buy-here-pay-here car lots. Informal loans with social pressure attached. “Flip your gate money” hustles and fake investment offers targeting the recently released. Lending to family that is really giving. Cash cushions raided because they are visible at home. Prepaid card fee bleed and check-cashing costs (defined in Banking & Credit; appear here only inside decision scenarios). Phone and subscription plans that quietly eat the margin.

8. Paper-based activities

- **The Bill Stack.** Envelope of bill cards, not enough money; sort into pay now / negotiate / later under a time limit; compare orders in pairs.
- **Good Week / Bad Week.** Two income cards, one plan; the plan must survive both.
- **The \$60 Shock.** After the plan is made, a shock card lands mid-exercise. What moves? What must not move?
- **Emergency or Not?** Card sort: real emergency, expense that was coming anyway, pressure or urge dressed up as urgent.
- **The Family Ask.** Short role-play with scripted openers; one honest sentence that is not yes and not never.
- **Cushion Ladder.** Rungs from \$0 to one month of rent (labels illustrative); learner circles the realistic first rung and a date.
- **Fast Money Menu.** Realistic offers for the same \$250 need; rank by true cost; costs revealed after ranking.
- **First 30 Days of Spending.** Capstone map, dual-track. Feeds on the Banking & Credit 30-day setup plan (section 14).

9. Facilitator risks

Shame triggers when real numbers are tiny; never require sharing amounts aloud, worksheets stay private. Learners may disclose unpaid court obligations or supervision problems; facilitator redirects to officer or legal aid and does not advise (boundary script needed in the guide). Mixed room drift: dual-track worksheets keep both

engaged. The Family Ask role-play can surface real conflict; keep it script-based, not testimony. Facility rules may restrict discussing gate money amounts or envelope materials; implementation guide needs a materials variance note. Emotional flooding during the shock exercise; trauma-aware pacing, permission to step back to a fictional character card at any point.

10. Take-home / reentry action step

Pre-release: complete the first-week-out money map in estimates, plus a wallet-size card with their one-line emergency definition. Post-release: sort their real bill stack once this week and set the first cushion rung with a date, even if the rung is zero. Both: one sentence they will use the next time someone asks for money.

11. Source items needed

Topic	Source needed	Priority
Small-shock statistic (e.g. share of adults unable to cover a \$400 expense)	Federal Reserve SHED, current year, dated	High
Payday loan cost ranges	CFPB, dated	High
Supervision fee ranges	State-specific; jurisdiction-tag; possibly per-state insert sheet	High
Gate money amounts	State-specific; label carefully, verify; consider omitting exact figures	Medium
Cash-advance app fee structures	CFPB or dated review	Medium
Prepaid/check-cashing fees	Reuse Banking & Credit claim ledger; do not re-source	Medium

12. Assumptions made

Mixed pre-release and early post-release learners (per Dalia). Paper-first, no internet in class, facility-ready, pencil-only, black-and-white printable, no phones, no calculators required; all math simple enough by hand (D-10). 4 sessions x 90 minutes plus optional 5th capstone, each standalone-usable (D-10). Dual-track approved: shared worksheets where possible, pre-release uses estimates, post-release uses real numbers; separate variants only when a shared sheet would confuse (D-10). State-neutral module; state-specific items carry source-needed notes instead of figures (D-10). Banking & Credit is recommended before this module but this module must stand alone. Dollar figures in activities will be labeled illustrative until sourced.

13. Open questions (all 5 RESOLVED by Dalia 2026-07-02, logged as D-10)

1. Session count: 4 sessions + optional 5th capstone/review; each session standalone-usable.
2. States: state-neutral for now; source-needed notes for supervision fees, child support, wage garnishment, public benefits, legal aid, court obligations.
3. Materials: paper-first, pencil-only, black-and-white printable, no internet, no phones, no calculators required; hand-math only. Card sorts work as cut-or-fold single sheets.
4. Dual-track: approved; shared worksheets where possible, separate variants only when clarity requires.
5. Debt-module boundary: collections rights, debt validation, restitution strategy, child support modification, and court/legal strategy stay in the future Debt / Restitution / Child Support module. Here: budgeting impact, prioritization, and routing language only (“ask early, ask in writing, get help from the right office”).

14. Connection to Banking & Credit (without repeating it)

Clean seam: **Banking & Credit answers where money lives; this module answers where money goes.**

- B&C Week 6 produces the “30-day money setup plan” (open the account, direct deposit, credit actions, debt first-steps). This module’s capstone (First 30 Days of Spending) takes that setup as input and plans the flow through it. Cross-reference by name, never re-teach.
- Where to keep the cushion: one pointer to B&C’s account guidance (second-chance, Bank On). This module only adds the behavioral piece: visible cash gets raided, separate is safer.
- Predatory products: definitions and deep treatment live in B&C. Here they appear only as options inside decision scenarios (Fast Money Menu), with a “see Banking & Credit” pointer.
- Debt and collections: B&C covers first steps and rights pointers; the queued Debt/Restitution/Child Support module will go deep. This module strictly triages which obligation gets paid this week.
- Shared glossary terms (emergency fund, overdraft, payday loan) use the master glossary definitions verbatim.

Partner-Network Checklist: Budgeting & Emergency Savings (v0.2)

Program: Correctional and Reentry | Version: v0.2 (post-audit) | Date: 2026-07-03 | Status: Needs Dalia review Supersedes v0.1 (kept as history). Applies all approved audit fixes and the owner decision on the minimum viable resource sheet; change list in end matter. Companion to the facility implementation guide v0.2 (MOU, resource sheet) and follow-up survey v0.2 (trusted-partner distribution). One network per site; refresh with the resource sheet (60-day verification rule).

The network exists so the class can keep its promises: every routing script in the course points somewhere real, and the 90-day survey travels through trust, never through supervision channels.

1. The roles a site needs covered

Two types, and the difference matters:

- **Partner:** a relationship. Named person, acknowledged rules (section 4), and for the trusted reentry partner, a written agreement. Partners are “in the network.”
- **Directory line:** a verified contact on the resource sheet. No agreement, no relationship required, never described as part of the network. The supervision payment office is a phone number the class routes questions to; it is not, and must never be presented as, a program partner.

Role	Type	What they do for this program	Maps to
Host (facility / reentry nonprofit / workforce program)	Partner	Room, roster, schedule, MOU signature	Implementation guide sections 1, 3
Trusted reentry partner	Partner (written agreement)	Post-release contact point; distributes and returns the 90-day survey; receives warm referrals	Survey Part A; section 2 below
Legal aid (civil)	Partner (referral receiver) or Directory line	Receives court-fee, debt, and collections questions the class routes out	Resource sheet; scripts 4, 9

Role	Type	What they do for this program	Maps to
Benefits navigator / benefits office	Directory line (Partner if a navigator relationship exists)	SNAP, Medicaid, reactivation questions	Resource sheet; script 8 routing
Health / medication resource ID / documents help	Directory line	Medication-gap questions (Session 1 shock card)	Resource sheet
Workforce / job center	Directory line	Birth certificate ordering, state ID, fee waivers where they exist	Resource sheet; S02
Transportation help	Partner or Directory line	Employment programs, reentry-friendly hiring	Resource sheet
Financial access pointer (credit union / CDFI / Bank On contact)	Directory line	Reduced fare, workforce transit funds	Resource sheet
Community help line (211-style)	Directory line only	Where B&C's account content points locally; pointer, never promotion	Resource sheet; CL-15
Housing support	Directory line	The no-personal-network first call on S20 wallet cards	Resource sheet
Supervision / payment office contact (if applicable)	Partner or Directory line	Transitional, emergency, rental assistance intake	Resource sheet
	Directory line only, always	The "right office" the S16 early-ask script names	Resource sheet

Multi-role rule: one organization may fill several roles if it meets each role's requirements. The trusted reentry partner can never be a supervising agency or any organization whose function includes reporting to supervision (criterion 1 controls). The host may also be the trusted partner if it passes all criteria.

2. What “trusted reentry partner” means (minimum criteria)

The survey and the warm-referral path both depend on this role. An organization qualifies when ALL of these are true:

- ☐ 1. It serves people after release in a non-supervisory role (it cannot violate, sanction, or report to supervision as its function)
- ☐ 2. It has an existing relationship channel with participants (case work, peer support, housing, employment services) so a survey hand-off is a natural contact, not a summons
- ☐ 3. It agrees in writing to the survey rules: optional, no coaching, sealed returns within two weeks, no copies kept, no individual answers shared with anyone
- ☐ 4. It accepts the no-compensation rule (MOU item 13): nothing of value for referrals, listings, or survey returns
- ☐ 5. A named person, not just an organization, owns the relationship
- ☐ 6. It can realistically reach participants around day 90 (ongoing case contact, alumni group, or standing appointment), and expects to be operating then

If no organization meets all six, the site has no trusted reentry partner, and the survey’s no-partner rule applies: no post-release distribution, ever, through supervision channels.

The written agreement uses the one-page **Trusted Partner Agreement** (print-pack deliverable): survey rules, no-compensation, no-data-flow, day-90 reach, sealed-envelope handling, and a pointer to the facilitator guide’s principles page.

3. Per-partner record (fill one per covered role)

Field	Entry
Organization	
Type (Partner / Directory line)	
Named contact + role	
Backup contact (optional, if the org can name one)	
Phone / address for the resource sheet	
What we route to them	
What they agreed to (referral intake? survey distribution? directory listing only?)	
Written agreement needed? (trusted partner: yes, the one-pager; other partners: MOU acknowledgment; directory lines: no)	
Verified by / date	
Re-verify by (60-day rule before each cohort)	

4. Boundaries that bind the network

- **No compensation, commission, referral fee, or benefit of any kind, in either direction, for any referral, listing, or survey activity** (MOU item 13). A partner that proposes one is removed from the network.
- **No product sales through the network.** The financial-access line is a pointer, never a promotion; no partner markets products to learners through the class (MOU item 12).
- **No advice laundering.** Partners receive routed questions; the class never presents a partner's answer as the class's advice. Legal answers come from legal aid, benefits answers from the benefits office, on their letterhead, not ours.
- **No conditioned referrals.** A partner may charge for its own services, but referral from this class never obligates a learner, and no partner may condition its free help on buying anything.
- **No data flow.** Partners never receive learner rosters, worksheets, assessment results, or survey answers. Survey mechanics are envelope-sealed: the learner seals their own completed form; the trusted partner returns envelopes unopened. (One envelope per survey ships in the print pack.) Referrals move by the learner's own choice and hand.
- **Honesty about gaps.** An unfilled role appears on the resource sheet as: **"No local line verified as of [date]."** Never a dead number. Gaps are told to the facilitator so the scripts route realistically ("legal aid where it is available").

5. Minimum viable resource sheet (owner decision, 2026-07-03)

The class launches when these **five lines are verified** (name, contact, checked date):

1. Community help line (211-style)
2. Legal aid, or the nearest equivalent with a named referral path
3. Benefits office or navigator
4. ID / documents help
5. One employment / workforce line

All other roles may honestly read **"No local line verified as of [date]."** A sheet below the five-line floor means the site is not ready to launch; fix the lines, not the standard.

6. Build sequence (fits the implementation timeline)

2-4 weeks before launch: identify candidates for every role; mark each Partner or Directory line; apply the section 2 test to the trusted-partner candidate; collect the signed Trusted Partner Agreement; fill per-partner records; build the resource sheet from the records; confirm the five-line floor is met; order print pack including survey envelopes.

Week of class: verify every line is answerable (one call or check each); print the resource sheet with any "no local line verified as of [date]" entries; brief the facilitator on the gaps.

During the program: log which routes learners actually ask about (counts only,

kept with the facilitator's class notes, no names, never with the roster); dead or unresponsive lines get fixed before the next session, not the next cohort.

After the final session: confirm the trusted partner's survey window and return logistics; hand the partner the sealed distribution set (forms + one envelope each) per survey Part A.

Each new cohort: 60-day re-verification of every line; re-confirm the trusted partner still meets all six criteria.

7. One-glance completeness check

- ☐ Every covered role typed (Partner / Directory line) with organization + named person or verified contact + date
- ☐ **Five-line floor met** (help line, legal aid or equivalent, benefits, ID help, employment)
- ☐ Trusted reentry partner passes all six criteria, Trusted Partner Agreement signed, or the no-partner rule is invoked
- ☐ Resource sheet generated from the records; gaps read "No local line verified as of [date]"; no dead numbers
- ☐ Survey envelopes in the print pack
- ☐ No-compensation, no-conditioned-referrals, and no-data-flow rules acknowledged by every Partner
- ☐ Gaps named to the facilitator
- ☐ Re-verification date on the calendar

Grant-Funder One-Pager: Budgeting & Emergency Savings (v0.2)

Program: Correctional and Reentry | Version: v0.2 (post-audit) | Date: 2026-07-03 | Status: Needs Dalia review (then held until counsel read + ledger v0.5 close, per launch plan) Supersedes v0.1 (kept as history). Applies all approved audit fixes. Drafted FROM the claims ledger v0.2; zero statistics by design (CL-12 held ledger-only per Dalia); no pricing (owner decision pending). CL references are internal and stripped at formatting.

Budgeting & Emergency Savings

A practical money-decisions course for reentry, from Financially Sovereign Academy

Program status: materials complete and internally audited; first pilot cohort pending; funding at this stage supports pilot delivery and refinement.

The problem it addresses. In the first months after incarceration, money arrives small and irregular while obligations arrive fixed and stacked. One small shock, a bus pass, a tool, a fee, can break a month, and the most available money in a bad week is usually the most expensive. This course assumes neither steady income nor stable housing.

What the course is. Four 90-minute sessions plus an optional capstone, paper-first, built for correctional facilities, reentry nonprofits, and workforce programs. No internet, no phones, no calculators; all math is one step at a time by hand. Works for mixed pre-release and post-release groups (estimates track and real-numbers track on the same worksheets) and for mixed literacy (whole-group read-aloud is the default). It is the second program in FSA's correctional series; the series' first program, Banking & Credit Rebuilding, is live with a full print-ready deliverable set.

What learners practice. Not category budgeting. Decisions under pressure:

- Triage: deciding what gets paid when everything cannot be paid, and in what order
- The floor: planning to the smallest week instead of the average, when pay changes weekly
- The early ask: handling a bill, fee, or family request with a number, a date, and a written record
- True cost: comparing fast-money options by total cost and by risk to the thing that earns the money
- The zero-dollar emergency plan: a wallet-card contingency plan that works before any savings exist

The course is built so a learner can say: when money is short, I can slow the damage, protect the next step, ask early, and keep one option open.

What the package includes. Student workbook (four sessions of scenario-based de-

cision practice), facilitator guide with verbatim boundary scripts, facility implementation guide with a 15-item partner agreement checklist, matched pre/post assessment, a 90-day follow-up survey, and a partner-network checklist. All materials are black-and-white printable and facility-ready.

How it is measured, honestly. A pre/post decision-and-confidence measure built for this curriculum (it is a program-built measure, not a validated scale) [CL-20], and an optional 90-day follow-up survey that asks what learners tried after the course. Reporting is aggregate only. Follow-up reports always state surveys distributed, returned, and answered, and findings are framed as: “Of those who responded, X said they tried [behavior]” [CL-28]. This program does not make recidivism claims or financial-outcome promises; it reports decision-skill and confidence change, and tried behaviors, and nothing more [CL-29].

Privacy is part of the design. Learner worksheets are never collected. The assessment uses learner-chosen codes, never names or ID numbers; individual results are never shared with supervision officers, case managers, employers, housing programs, or funders; forms are destroyed on a fixed schedule; and every request for individual results is logged and refused. Facilities sign a plain-language agreement covering custody, access, destruction, and referral boundaries before the first class.

What the program will not do. No financial, legal, tax, or credit-repair advice. No product sales, no compensated referrals, no brand promotion. State-specific questions (supervision fees, child support, benefits) are routed to the right office or to legal aid, in writing; teaching that routing is part of the curriculum.

What funding supports. Pilot delivery: printing and materials, facilitator training and delivery, per-facility localization (a verified local resource sheet for every site), measurement and aggregate reporting, and post-pilot refinement. Spanish-language adaptation is scoped as a follow-on once the English pilot is complete. Budget available on request.

Delivery requirements for a host site. A room with tables, pencils, 90-minute blocks, a signed partner agreement, and a verified local resource sheet. Nothing else.

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